



WNHS PROCEDURE	
Escort Procedures	
Scope (Staff):	Mental health staff working in WNHS
Scope (Area):	WHGMH, MBU

1. Aim

There may be times that Mother and Baby Unit (MBU) inpatients are required to attend appointments either external or internal to the health service. Staff may also be required to escort MBU patients to the shops or during group activities off the ward. The purpose of this procedure is to provide direction and information to mental health clinical staff of the Mother and Baby Unit (MBU) in regard to maintaining a level of supervision when escorting patients outside of the unit.

Note: These procedures are to be read in conjunction with [Risk Management MBU Procedure](#).

2. Background

The MBU aspires to ensure the rights of a woman and partner/support person are met according to [Charter of Mental Health Care Principles](#) (Mental Health Act (MHA) 2014). Leave for admitted mental health patients is encouraged to support person-centred recovery, sustain community-based living and ensure that treatment is provided in the least restrictive manner possible.

3. Risk

Non-compliance with this policy will:

Breach legislative requirements	☒	Impact on Patient Quality of Care	☐
Breach National/State/Mandatory Policy	☒	Impact on Patient Safety	☒
Breach professional standards	☐	Impact financial operations	☐
Damage NMHS reputation	☐	Impact on Staff Safety	☐
Other	☐		

4. Principles

- The treating team will determine if a staff escort is required based on the patient risk assessment and clinical needs.

- All proposed staff escorts will be discussed with and coordinated by the respective CNC/CNM or shift coordinator.
- Travel arrangements will be confirmed in advance – I.e. government car, taxi.
- When determining the type of transport required consideration should be given to:
 - Known risk factors
 - Behavioural concerns
 - Timing of appointment
 - Nominated carer/ support person involvement
 - Staff availability
- The escort will be advised to remain with the patient until she:
 - Returns with them
 - Hands them over to another person who takes over responsibility for the patients care
 - The reason for the escort is completed.
- Nursing students will not escort a patient unless they are accompanied by another staff member
- Nominated Personal Support People [PSP], carers, community managed organisations may escort patients off site if agreed by the treating team.
- CNC mobile phone to be use by staff on escort. Phone will be programmed with ward numbers and security number if required.

5. Procedure

- The shift coordinator and nurse escort will discuss any risk factors and appropriate management strategies with the escort and request they inform staff when the patient has returned to the ward
- The following details should be documented in the medical file
 - Risk assessment and management plan
 - Physical Appearance
 - Prescribed medication for that period if required.
- Staff escorting the patient will ensure that prescribed medications are available for the patient if required. Medications will be dispensed by pharmacy following leave script being completed by Doctor.
- Staff to ensure that ward mobile phone is charged and must remain with the staff member for the duration of the escort.

Duties During Escort

- Maintain visual contact and remain in close proximity with the patient where possible
- Provide clinical handover as per the WNHS [Clinical Handover guideline](#) as required
- Document escort outcomes in the medical file and ISOFT handover
- Notify shift coordinator of return to unit and escort outcome

The same risk considerations will be made for escorting patients as part of a group activity or for local trips to the shops.

- Individual risk assessment and clinical needs
- CNC mobile phone to be used by staff on escort
- Nursing students will not escort a patient unless they are accompanied by another staff member
- Staff need to be cognisant of the patient mix and ensure there is adequate staff to manage the complexity of escorting group.

Related internal policies, procedures and guidelines

[Charter of Mental Health Care Principles](#)

[Risk Management Procedure - MBU](#)

[Women's and Perinatal Mental Health Referral and Management Guideline](#)

[Applying the MHA in WNHS](#)

Related Legislation

[Mental Health Act 2014](#)

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Policy Author	Coordinator of Nursing – Mental Health				
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NSQHS Standards Applicable:	 Std 1: Clinical Governance  Std 2: Partnering with Consumers		 Std 5: Comprehensive Care  Std 6: Communicating for Safety		
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The health impact upon Aboriginal people has been considered, and where relevant incorporated and appropriately addressed in the development of this policy (insert ISD Number). (Please refer to the

Aboriginal Health Impact Statement and Declaration for Department of Health and Health Service Provider Guidelines – please delete once you have completed this).

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